

Chile



A long, narrow country west of the Andes that has made a peaceful return to democracy.

1540 A Spanish expedition led by Pedro de Valdivia crosses the Andes from Peru and founds several cities, including Santiago in 1541. Lautaro, the leader of the Araucanian Indians, who offer fierce resistance, is killed in 1557. Valdivia is killed by the Araucanians in 1554.

1817 José de San Martín, revolutionary leader in Argentina against Spanish rule, leads an army across the Andes and routs the Spaniards at the Battle of Chacabuco.

1817–18 Bernardo O'Higgins leads the republican Army of the Andes in victories against royalist Spanish forces.

1818 The Battle of Maipú pits the independence army, assisted by San Martín's liberation forces, against the remaining Spanish forces and ensures Chilean independence.

1818–23 As autocratic leader of the new republic, Bernardo O'Higgins, formerly Viceroy of Peru and known as "the Liberator," lays the political foundations of an oligarchic state that are later consolidated in the constitution of 1833.

1829–30 After a civil war between Liberals and Conservatives, Conservative alliance led by Diego Portales seizes power.

1836–39 During a war against Peru, which Chile wins, Portales is assassinated.

1879–84 Chile emerges enriched from the Pacific War, waged against Bolivia and Peru over control of nitrate-producing areas and the port of Antofagasta. Chile extends its territory northward and ends Bolivia's access to the coast.

1886–91 Presidency of José Manuel Balmaceda, a Liberal, is characterized by a struggle between presidential and congressional authority, and ends in a bloody civil war in 1891.

1902 Chile extends southward into Patagonia and on to the island of Tierra del Fuego, shared jointly with Argentina.

1920 Election of President Arturo Alessandri—"The Lion"—who introduces social and labor reforms. His policies are blocked by the legislature, and he resigns in 1924 but is recalled in 1925 after the army intervenes to support him; a revised constitution bolsters his powers.

1929 Chile loses a chunk of northern territory to Peru in brief war.

1932 A coup installs the 100-day "Socialist Republic" of Carlos Davila.

1936–46 Communist, Radical, and Socialist parties form the Popular Front coalition, taking power in 1938.



Bernardo O'Higgins

The illegitimate son of an Irishman in Spanish government service, O'Higgins spent his childhood in Europe but returned to Chile in 1802 committed to its independence.

1946–64 Right-wing presidents follow US policy and marginalize the left.

1970 Salvador Allende is the world's first democratically elected Marxist president.

1973 Allende dies in US-backed military coup. Brutal dictatorship of General Augusto Pinochet begins, who imprisons, tortures, and kills many of his opponents.

1988 Referendum votes no to Pinochet staying in power.

1989 Democracy peacefully restored; Pinochet steps down after Patricio Aylwin of the Christian Democratic Party (PDC) wins an election victory.

1998 Pinochet is detained while on a visit to the UK, pending extradition to Spain on human rights abuse charges. He is released on health grounds.

2000 Ricardo Lagos of the Socialist Party (PS) sworn in as president. Pinochet, who has returned to Chile, is deemed unfit to face trial, and is released.

2004 Divorce is legalized.

2006 Michelle Bachelet (PS) wins election as first woman president. Pinochet dies at age 91.

2010 Sebastian Pinera wins elections, becoming the first right-wing president for 20 years. Central Chile earthquake kills hundreds. After an explosion, 33 miners are trapped underground, but are all safely rescued after 69 days.

«214–15 Aztec to Inca
«318–19 Latin America Liberated
«422–23 Viva la Revolución
«438–39 Dictatorship and Democracy

Uruguay



A republic originally set up to act as a buffer state between Argentina and Brazil.

1624 Spanish found first permanent settlement at Soriano in southwest of the country; the Portuguese then found a settlement in 1680, and fortify a hill in present-day Montevideo in 1717, starting a colonial rivalry between the two nations over control of Uruguay.

1726 Spaniards found Montevideo. By end of the century, the whole country is divided into large cattle ranches.

1811 Patriotic rancher and local caudillo, José Gervasio Artigas, declares Montevideo independent from Brazil.

1812–20 Uruguayans, known as Orientales ("Easterners," from the eastern side of the River Plate), fight wars against Argentinian and Brazilian invaders.

1821 Brazil annexes Montevideo.

1827 General Lavalleja defeats Brazilians with Argentine help.

1828 Seeing trade benefits that an independent Uruguay would bring as a buffer state between Argentina and Brazil, Britain mediates and secures Uruguayan independence.

1836 Start of large-scale European immigration.

1838–65 La Guerra Grande civil war between Blancos (Whites, future conservative party) and Colorados (Reds, future liberals).

1865–70 Colorado president General Venancio Flores, takes Uruguay into the War of the Triple Alliance against Paraguay.

1872 Peace under military rule. Blancos strong in country; Colorados in cities.

1890s Violent strikes by immigrant trade unionists against landed elite enriched by massive European investment in ranching.

1903–07 Reformist Colorado, José Batllé y Ordóñez, is president.

1911–15 Batllé's second term in office. Batllismo creates the first welfare state in Latin America, with pensions and free education and health service; also implements nationalizations, church is disestablished, and death penalty abolished.

1933 Following a military coup, opposition groups are excluded from politics.

1939–45 Uruguay remains neutral during World War II.

1942 President Alfredo Baldomir dismisses the government and tries to bring back proper representation.

1951 New constitution replaces president with nine-member council. Decade of great prosperity follows until world agricultural prices plummet.

1958 Blancos win elections for the first time in 93 years.

1962 Tupamaros urban guerrilla group founded. Its campaign lasts until 1973.

1966 The presidency is reinstated.

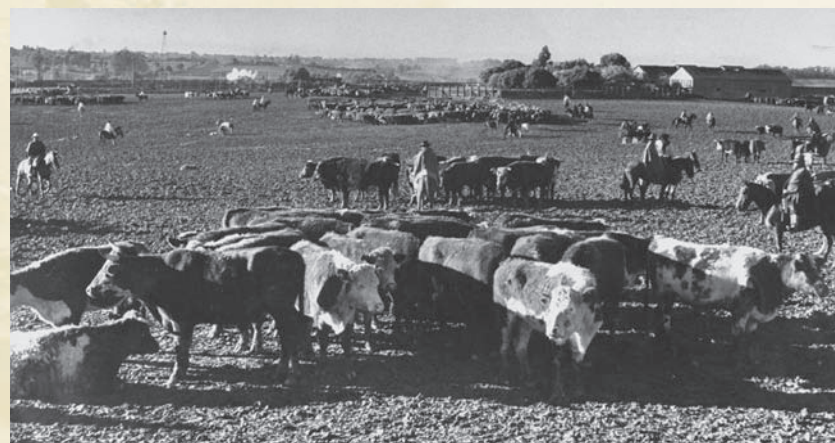
1967 Jorge Pacheco becomes president, introducing tough anti-inflation policies.

1973 Military coup: the army promises to encourage foreign investment. Political freedoms are denied and the left is brutally repressed. 400,000 emigrate.

1984–85 Military steps down: Julio Sanguinetti (Colorado) wins a new presidential election.

1986 Those guilty of human rights abuses are granted amnesty.

1989 Referendum endorses amnesty in interest of stability. Elections won by Lacalle Herrera and Blancos.



Living off the land

Sometimes described as a large cattle ranch with a country attached, Uruguay is a successful wool and meat exporter. Livestock products bring in more than a third of current export earnings. On the country's vast *estancias* (above), the gaucho way of life predominates.